

They scaled walls and even the roofs of standalone public toilets just to catch a glimpse of their favourite cricketers. Private bouncers tried shooing them away, but the hundred-odd fans refused to budge.

With no spectators allowed at the Jaipuria Vidyalaya ground, there was no legitimate way for fans to watch the cricketers in action. As the Vijay Hazare Trophy progressed, however, they found ways, one way or another, to fulfil their dreams.

While a few climbed trees and several others peeked from the roofs of toilets, quite a few overenthusiastic youngsters turned YouTubers and vloggers, hoping to sneak into the media zone.

Security personnel and officials from the BCCI's anti-corruption unit, however, remained alert. No one without a valid media accreditation was allowed entry into the makeshift media tent.

Still, moments of access arrived unexpectedly. Whenever Shreyas Iyer or Suryakumar Yadav walked out to bat, a few fans managed to get closer, striking up conversations with academy students and tagging along with them to the gallery. It was never guaranteed, and never comfortable, but it was better than watching shadows from a distance.

As fans devised new strategies each day to evade security and enter the ground, questions began to surface over why high-profile

domestic fixtures were being staged at venues where the public had no real access.

Nearly 20,000 spectators had turned up at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium to watch Rohit Sharma. Yet most matches involving Mumbai and Punjab, teams stacked with India internationals including Shubman Gill, were scheduled at the Jaipuria Vidyalaya ground and the K.L. Saini Stadium, grounds that struggled to cope with the attention they attracted.

The BCCI maintained that venue allocations were made on the basis of suggestions from the Rajasthan Cricket Association (RCA), the host body. D.D. Kumawat, convenor of the RCA's ad-hoc committee, pointed out that the final call rested with the BCCI. With the Sawai Mansingh Stadium unavailable due to the Army Day Parade, he explained, hosting games there beyond January 3 was not an option.

"This is the prerogative of the BCCI. The fixtures were decided much in advance, and back then, there was no clarity about the availability of international players. And, with all four venues in the city hosting Vijay Hazare Trophy games, there's no way we could have shifted all the big games to the Sawai Mansingh Stadium," he told Sportstar.

Having queued up in large numbers to watch Rohit, they had hoped to follow Gill, Shreyas or Suryakumar from closer quarters. Instead, their memories of the

tournament were shaped by fleeting sights glimpsed from a rooftop or a silhouette framed in a distant window of a nearby apartment block.

Love from parents

As Yashasvi Jaiswal returned to action after recovering from acute gastroenteritis, his parents, Bhupendra Kumar Jaiswal and Kanchan, accompanied him to Jaipur. While their son turned out for Mumbai in a group league fixture against Goa, they watched quietly from the stands at the Jaipuria Vidyalaya ground.

Blending easily into the small gathering of local spectators, they spoke readily to those around them, answering questions, posing for photographs, and sharing fragments from their son's early years in the game.

"He has always been passionate about the game, and has battled all odds to pursue the sport," Bhupendra said with a smile, as



Biggest supporters: In a small corner of the Jaipuria Vidyalaya ground, Yashasvi Jaiswal's parents blend into the crowd, watching their son in action. SHAYANACHARYA

« As fans improvised ways in, questions grew over why high-profile domestic matches were played beyond public reach »